TikTok & your child:
a parent's plain-english safety guide

CYBER SAFETY GUY

Introduction

> I spent 8 years inside the evidence.
> Now I spend my time making sure children never become part of it.

Dala McGleenon's background in digital forensics provides the authority for this guide, but his goal is to provide warm, direct support for worried parents.

WHAT IS TIKTOK AND WHY CHILDREN LOVE IT

Short videos
Fast, fun and addictive 10–60 second videos.

Discoverability
The 'For You' feed shows content based on what they watch.

Trends & challenges
Trendy sounds, dances and challenges keep kids engaged.

Creative expression
Easy tools to create, remix and share.

The risks parents need to understand

Inappropriate content
Mature themes, violence and harmful content can appear in feeds.

Stranger contact
Public accounts and comments can lead to unwanted contact.

Privacy and data
TikTok collects personal data which is stored and used by the platform.

Screen time
Endless scrolling can impact sleep, focus and mental wellbeing.

Pressure and self-image
Perfect-lcrolling content can harm confidence and create comparison stress.

In-app spending
Live gifts and in-app purchases can be easy to access and costly.

Step-by-step security guide

1. Set up Family Pairing
Go to Profile > ☰ > Settings and privacy > Family Pairing. Link your account with your child's.

2. Make the account private
Settings > Privacy > Private account. Only approved followers can see their content.

3. Control comments
Settings > Privacy > Comments. Choose 'Friends' or turn off comments.

4. Filter content
Settings > Content preferences > Filter video keywords. Add words you don't want them to see.

5. Manage screen time
Settings > Screen time. Set a daily time limit and sleep hours to pause the app.

6. Restrict Direct Messages
Settings > Privacy > Direct messages. Limit who can send DMs to 'Friends' or 'No one'.

7. Turn off Personalised Ads
Settings > Privacy > Personalisation and data > Ad settings > Turn off personalised ads.

The 10-minute conversation

- Ask open questions: "What do you enjoy most on TikTok?"
- Talk about trends, challenges and who they follow.
- Explain why some content may not be real or safe.
- Agree on rules around time, followers and sharing.
- Remind them they can always come to you.

The "10-minute chat"

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use the app, focusing on understanding their world rather than judging it.

If things go wrong

Stay calm and take screenshots — Save evidence of the content, messages or profile.

Report on TikTok — Use the in-app report button on the video, profile or message.

Report and seek help — Contact CEOP (ceop.police.uk) or Childline for support.

For serious concerns, contact your local police.

Closing

Onwards & Upwards

Staying on top of digital safety is hard work, but you are not alone in this fight.

Childline support: If you or a child you know needs support, Childline is available 24/7 at **0800 1111** or **childline.org.uk**.